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BROTHERS UNSEATED Once hailed as heroes, Mahinda (left) and Gotabaya Rajapaksa are now blamed by the people for the crisis that has engulfed Sri Lanka

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desperate Gotabaya looked to form an all-party government, but there were few takers, and he appointed once archrival Ranil Wickremesinghe prime minister and handed him the finance ministry as well. By then, the country was bankrupt and all the new PM could do was let the public know the appalling state of the country's economy and initiate talks with the IMF. With the new premier unable to offer any instantaneous relief to deeply frustrated and angry Sri Lankans and two months to the day that Mahinda had to make an abrupt exit from office, the tide turned against Gotabaya in the same dramatic way—on July 9 thousands of protesters broke into the President's House in Colombo, the presidential secretariat as well as Temple Trees, the official residence of the prime minister and occupied them. Gotabaya was whisked away to safety and remained under heavy military guard in undisclosed locations. In the early hours of 13 July, he was flown in a Sri Lanka Air Force aircraft along with his spouse and two security personnel to the Maldives, from where he is expected to leave for another country.

The Sri Lankan military has remained on the sidelines, even though rumours of their intervention if the country descends into lawlessness were going round. The only official comment has come from the country's highest serving military officer, Chief of Defence Staff General Shavendra Silva, who sought public support for the armed forces and the police to ensure peace and urged people to act according to the constitution. Military personnel who were called in to assist the police have remained restrained in their actions toward the protesters.

All political parties represented in parliament have held talks to form an all-party government to see the country through at least the next six difficult months before going for fresh parliamentary polls, but there is little agreement as yet. Although Gotabaya has gone, the Rajapaksas' SLPP has the majority in the country's 225-seat legislature, which gives them controlling power, including over who becomes president and prime minister. At the last parliamentary polls in August 2020, the Party secured 145 seats, with Samagi Jana Balawegaya (SJB), the main opposition party, garnering only 54 seats. The Tamil National Alliance (TNA), which represents the Tamil community who live predominantly in the North and East of the country, has 10 seats. Ranil Wickremesinghe won the only seat of the United Nationalist Party (UNP). Since the crisis began, at least 42 MPs who were part of the ruling party have announced they will function as independent MPs, but have said they will support the government in parliament when necessary.

The vote for the next president looks divisive, with SJB chief Sajith Premadasa, son of the late Sri Lankan president Ranasinghe Premadasa, is among those in the fray to succeed Gotabaya. However, his party lacks enough MPs to win the vote scheduled for July 20. Wickremesinghe is expected to contest with the support of a segment of the SLPP, while another senior